MAKING BENGAL A MAGNET FOR INDUSTRY

The divisive rhetoric of the poll campaign over, Suvendu Adhikari gets down to the task of providing inclusive governance, while bringing industry and jobs to the state

By **ARKAMOY DATTA MAJUMDAR**



DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

Suvendu Adhikari could not have ushered in the new era in Bengal politics on a better day—May 9, 2026, the 165th birth anniversary of poet laureate Rabindranath Tagore. And the new chief minister and his Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) made the most of it, from the portrait of Tagore on the stage and Rabindra Sangeet during the swearing-in ceremony to Suvendu's visit to Jorasanko Thakurbari, Tagore's ancestral home, where he paid floral tributes to the 'kabiguru' and recited his poem, '*Chitto jetha bhoy shunyo* (where the mind is without fear)'. '*Bhoy*' (fear), he echoed Union home minister Amit Shah's words, had now given way to '*Bhorosha*' (trust).

The occasion is heady enough for Suvendu to wax eloquent. The 55-year-old is the ninth overall and the BJP's first chief minister of Bengal, handing the saffron party its final prize in the east, that too with an astounding 207-seat majority in a House of 294. Gone is the divisive, acrimonious rhetoric of the poll campaign, and in its place is a calmer, more inclusive language. "Now, I am CM, I belong to everyone." "It is not 'I', it is 'we, we, and we'." "This is a government 'of the people, by the people, for the people', not 'for the party'."

But Suvendu will need more than words to honour the weighty mandate he has been given. He may have been the architect of the Nandigram agitation and the subsequent rise of the Trinamool Congress (TMC), but development has long been held hostage to politics in Bengal, first under 34 years of Left rule, then playing second fiddle to Mamata Banerjee's welfare architecture for 15 years. It has left the state without any industry, and its youth deprived of job opportunities. Doles and welfare schemes can take you only so far, as Didi discovered, and though the BJP intends to continue down that road, it will have to balance welfare expansion with fiscal discipline. Equally challenging will be the task of curbing